Intervening in social systems is a messy business, and very often, things go wrong. The Indian landscape is littered with outcomes that were the opposite of what was intended. APMCs were not intended to create entrenched power in the hands of traders. Land ceiling acts were not intended to create shortages of real estate and high prices for real estate. Bank nationalization was not intended to hamper growth, stability and inclusion.

Why do these things go wrong? Why do we joke about the ‘law of unintended consequences’ ? Many things are simultaneously going on, which work against us. [2]

Error: Our facts and our analytical models are incomplete; there is a ‘knowledge constraint’. We know less than we think. Hence, we make errors.

Wishful thinking: We suffer from ‘confirmation bias’; we tend to look for the facts that support our positions. Once a tentative position is taken, we lose objectivity. This has become a bigger issue in the world of electronic and social media, where it has become harder for a policymaker to change positions.

Political economy dominates: The ideal technocratic plan is never implemented in the real world. What will be put to field will always be tugged at by various political considerations, it will always be a suboptimal version of the starting point of the discussion. The best laid plans of well meaning intellectuals turn into a mess on the way to execution.

Limitations of execution: There is an administrative constraint holding up the translation of idea into execution. The frail management systems through which policy initiatives are implemented result in an intervention which diverges substantially from what was originally intended. Innovators in policy thinking often find themselves saying, some years later: *I did not mislead, you mis-followed*. To the extent that we take implementation constraints seriously in policy design, we will fare better.

The plan gets derailed: As the boxer Mike Tyson said, ‘Everybody has a plan until they get punched in the mouth.’ We start doing something, but unexpected events show up, and we are forced to respond.